

Getting AI Right: Overcoming Barriers to Agentic Transformation



AI tools such as copilots, assistants, and agents are transforming the way many organizations face a troubling paradox. Instead of simplifying workflows, poorly implemented AI can bog down teams, creating challenges for business leaders tasked with transforming processes while delivering returns.

For business leaders this is a pivotal moment. The next evolution of AI—autonomous, outcome-driven agents—has the potential to break this paradox. These systems can execute complex tasks, unlock new efficiencies, and deliver transformative business value. Success requires more than adopting technology; it demands intentionality, aligning AI with workflows, data, and strategic goals.

As AI evolves from a technology initiative to a business-wide opportunity, business leaders must lead the charge, ensuring the right AI is applied to the right challenges.

Three critical challenges

Explore the three critical challenges business leaders are facing in maximizing the impact of agentic AI—and how to overcome them to deliver meaningful results.

Challenge 01: Find your problem first

Agentic AI is not a goal. It's a mechanism to realize goals.

Empowering an entire organization to benefit from AI isn't just about adopting AI, it's about thoughtfully applying it to pain points and growth opportunities across an organization.

Increased use of AI throughout an organization without a clear vision for the communication and orchestration across the business sets the stage for productivity shortfalls—not the promise of AI that leaders expect.

This paradox emphasizes how important it is for business leaders to identify the right AI for the right process and find key high-value workflows to apply the right blend of AI for an AI-first organizational transformation.

Challenge 02: AI with a clear vision

Say “yes” to AI strategically

Invest in and focus on where AI can have the most impact

The average company is now using 254 AI-enabled apps¹—including apps not sanctioned by the business. Executives are acknowledging the sprawl and attempting to control it, as 84% of CIOs say that there are too many AI tools².

AI and AI agents are most valuable when intentionally integrated deeply into your organizations, working across the tools used every day to complete complex task. Focus on creating an open, orchestration layer that communicates and connects across your business data, workflows, and tools. This will effectively break siloes and create more value. A unified coordinated ecosystem will unlock a whole new level of what's possible.

"We have to continuously evaluate how AI goes into an environment and the potential impact it will have"

Matt Lyteson, CIO, Technology Platform Transformation, IBM

When to say “Yes” to AI agents or assistants

While the terms AI assistants and AI agents are often used interchangeably, AI assistants typically handle repetitive, well-defined tasks, whereas AI agents operate with greater autonomy—using reasoning to pursue outcomes with minimal human intervention.

Here are 6 questions to help you decide where to get started with AI agents or AI assistants.

6 questions to help you get started:

1. Which repetitive, well-defined or low value tasks are your employees spending time on?
2. Which decision-making processes follow predictable rules or patterns and can be improved or made faster with data-driven insights?
3. Are there workflows that span multiple systems or departments and suffer from handoff delays or manual coordination?
4. What high-impact goals can be accelerated if a system could act independently within defined guardrails?
5. Are there areas where customer service or employee satisfaction is lagging due to slow response times or inconsistency?
6. Do you have access to the data needed to support AI agents in this area—and is it trustworthy?

Wondering where to start?

If you’re wondering where to start, know that client support and customer service, human resources, digital procurement and IT modernization have all had a track record of producing quantifiable productivity gains by using AI agents and assistants.

For example, IBM’s AskHR has automated 80 different HR processes and 94% of simple tasks, such as vacation requests and pay statements. And across these various use cases [IBM has realized USD 4.5 billion in cost savings](#).

Challenge 03: Don’t isolate your AI

Integrating AI with other tools

AI agents are most impactful when they work with existing tools, applications, and automations.

But, even though integration is critical to unlocking AI's value, only 40% of CIOs feel fully prepared to manage and integrate AI technology into their existing business¹. Many AI agents and assistants currently operate in silos, which can be a barrier to moving from a fragmented adoption to systematic agentic AI mechanisms.

The value of agentic systems is the interactivity among multiple agents. AI agents can begin to work together to complete tasks, so people can focus on more strategic and high-value work. [IBM watsonx Orchestrate™](#) can help integrate, connect and manage all your AI agents in one place, and building agentic systems of multiple AI agents to help get more work done.

Integrating AI with humans

As AI becomes more integral in your business, barriers to using AI agents and assistants drop significantly, creating an environment where people with little or no tech skills can build AI agents for individual workflows, and organizations must prepare.

It's important to make sure that your employees have the right training and support not just to use AI, but to use it to drive maximum impact. Advocate for AI tools that are human-centric and make that determination with metrics that aren't solely based on business outcomes.

First, understand whether your AI tools are delivering on ease of use and freeing up your team from repetitive tasks. Then, calculate the percentage of AI users in your organization, track the frequency of AI use in daily work and assign a human-machine friction score to task where AI is used.

Are you transformation-ready?

Have you established responsible AI principles?

Setting guardrails is crucial as AI becomes an integral part of how your business operates. Define responsible AI practices, educate your teams, and keep humans in the loop in every step.

Which percentage of employees are trained on AI fundamentals?

According to an IBM Institute for Business Value study, CEOs said 31% of their workforce will require retraining and reskilling over the next 3 years. While reimagining processes and removing bottlenecks, identify where your people will need upskilling and use available fundamental AI training.

Are your CXOs participating in AI councils or task forces?

AI initiatives can quickly become fragmented and ineffective without strategic coordination. AI councils can help define your enterprise aligned AI strategy, establish policies, and facilitate knowledge sharing.

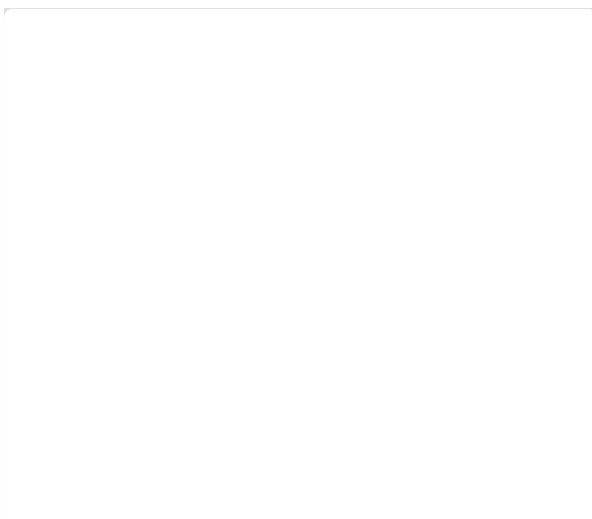
Are you reimagining your business processes for AI?

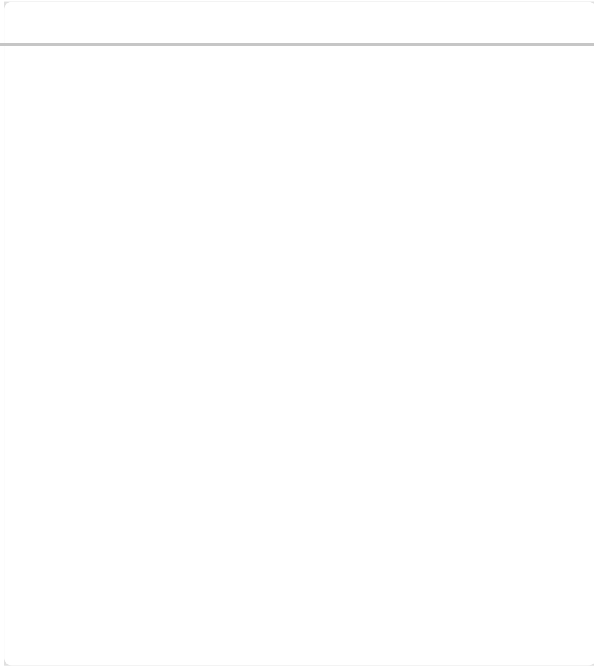
When you enhance and reimagine processes before automating or adding AI agents, you'll boost productivity beyond initial expectations and generate greater value.

Final thoughts

As you prepare for your ambitions as a business leader in an AI-first future, remember that the following can help you break the productivity paradox and achieve higher returns on AI.

- Identify the weaknesses or bottlenecks in your organization that can be solved with AI agents or assistants.
- Be disciplined in where you adopt AI; resist the AI fear of missing out (FOMO).
- Integrate your AI with your diverse ecosystems.
- Connect your AI to your existing data, applications, tools and employees.





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